

Unit 1: Programming (scripting) Bootcamp

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In this unit we'll study the very basics of programming using the [Julia](#) language, though the concepts apply to pretty much every major programming language with slight modifications to the syntax. The unit ends with suggested class micro-projects and practice questions for the upcoming quiz. The pace and nature of this unit is aimed at students with little or no programming experience. The units afterwards pick up the pace significantly.

What to expect from this unit:

- Variables

- Types
- Using in-built functions (e.g. `println`) and macros (e.g. `@show`)
- Logical statements (AND, OR, etc..)
- Conditional statements (`if-elseif-else`)
- For loops
- While loops
- Creating your own functions with (`function`)

1 Getting Started

Install Julia for your particular type of computer following the steps listed on the [Julia website](https://julialang.org). Then open a terminal on your computer and start Julia with the command ‘`julia`’. This should give you about the following output.

```
dietmar@Nina:~/github/MATH2504/ProgrammingCourse-with-Julia-SimulationAnalysisAndLearningSystems$ julia
```

```

      _       _       _
     (_      | (_   (_ |
      _ _    | |   _ _
     | | | | | | | / _ |
     | | | | | | | (_ |
    _/ | \ _ ' | | \ _ ' |
   |__/_/      |

Documentation: https://docs.julialang.org
Type "?" for help, "]"? for Pkg help.
Version 1.12.6 (2026-04-09)
Official https://julialang.org release

```

```
julia>
```

1.1 Command line interface (REPL) - using Julia as a calculator

The prompt `julia>` represents the Julia command line interface called **REPL** (Read-Eval-Print-Loop). Start by **using it as a calculator**, e.g. at the Julia prompt enter

```
5+6
```

```
11
```

```
or
```

```
sin(25/180)
```

```
0.13844278873711527
```

Here the function `sin` from the standard library is called.

1.2 Generating output - Hello World!

Another function from the standard library can be called as follows:

```
println("Hello World!")
```

```
Hello World!
```

We are calling (or invoking) the function `println` with the argument `"Hello World!"`. The name of the function refers to ‘Print (and go into the next) line’. It takes the argument (the text `"Hello World!"` in this case) and writes it into the next line after the command, finally ending the line and moving the cursor into the next line.

The `println` function can also take several arguments.

```
println("hello", " ", "world")
```

hello world

Here is `print` without a new line.

```
print("hello")
print(" ")
print("world")
```

hello world

The symbol `\n` represents a **new line**-command,

```
println("hello\nworld") #notice the \n (newline)
println("Here is the next line")
```

hello
world
Here is the next line

Round brackets after a name are the application of a function, kind of like in mathematics. Keep in mind that round brackets also have other uses: For example, dealing with the order of precedence of computations:

```
1 + 1 * 4
```

5

as compared to

```
(1 + 1) * 4
```

8

or something more involved such as

```
(1/sin(25/180)+2.3)
```

9.523200349560057

1.3 Macros

Note that ‘`@show`’ does something very similar to `println`. It is a **macro** (all macros have `@` in their names).

```
@show(3/425)
s="3.5";
@show s;
println(s)
```

3 / 425 = 0.007058823529411765

s = "3.5"

3.5

Macros are evaluated at compile time (when translating the Julia code into machine code) and therefore have access to more information, e.g. the variable name of their argument. For that reason `@show` can also output the variable name ‘`s`’ which is convenient for debugging, whereas `println` only has access to the content ‘3.5’ of its argument.

1.4 Using code editors

The *REPL* is great for using Julia as a calculator. **Multi-line input (scripts, programs)** can be **pasted line-by-line and sometimes even at once directly into the REPL**, but it is more convenient to **store it into a .jl file**, and then

- invoke the file line by line either from the terminal running ‘julia filename.jl’,
- or from the REPL using ‘include(“filename.jl”)’.

Or, you use a **dedicated editor**, e.g.

- install [VSCode](#) and, once you started the editor, install the Julia language extension. (If you can’t make it work, we’ll show you in the tutorials how to do this) and
- the [Jupyter notebook interface](#) which can be installed by running, line-after-line, in the REPL

```
using Pkg
Pkg.add("IJulia")
using IJulia
notebook()
```

1.5 Input a variable through user interaction

Store the following 3 lines into the file ‘test.jl’ and run it either by running the command ‘julia test.jl’ from the terminal or through include(“test.jl”) from the REPL, or directly from VSCode.

```
println("What is your name: ")
username=readline()
println("Hi ", username, ", how are you?")
```

This short script outputs the question about your name, and then used the function `readline` to read in your name and store it into the variable `name`. Finally it outputs a greeting which includes your particular name.

Try running this simple script in several ways:

- REPL (by running Julia and using the REPL, line after line)
- Jupyter (in a Jupyter notebook with Ctrl+Enter),
- In a file (by creating a file such as `my_code.jl` and either running `julia my_code.jl` from the terminal or include(“my_code.jl”) within the REPL)
- In VS-Code with the Julia extension.

2 Variables and types

In the last example the variable `username` acted as a container for the name the user would input. Indeed, one may think of variables as a **storage box**, with a name (tag) on it. The computer’s memory is the **storage facility** in which you can store all your boxes.



Figure 1: Variables are boxes in a storage facility (memory)

For example the command

```
x = 3
```

3

stores the value 3 in the box tagged x.

Later, you may retrieve the value stored in the variable x, for example the command

```
x + 25
```

28

retrieves the value stored in x and adds 25 to it.

The **assignment operator** = is also used to assign the value (content) of one variable to another variable, or assign the result of a computation to a variable,

```
y=x
z=y+5
println("Now x = ", x, ", y = ", y, " and z = ",z, ".")
```

Now x = 3, y = 3 and z = 8.

Algebraic operations on numbers

```
x = 3.0
y = 4.2
x*y, x+y, x-y, x/y, x^y
```

(12.600000000000001, 7.2, -1.2000000000000002, 0.7142857142857143, 100.90420610885693)

Mathematical functions

```
x = 2
√x #\sqrt + [TAB]
```

1.4142135623730951

```
sqrt(x)
```

1.4142135623730951

```
y = -x
```

-2

```
sqrt(y)
```

DomainError: DomainError(-2.0, "sqrt was called with a negative real argument but will only return a complex result if called with a complex argument. Try sqrt(Complex(x)).")

DomainError with -2.0:

sqrt was called with a negative real argument but will only return a complex result if called with a complex argument. Try sqrt(Complex(x)).

Stacktrace:

```
[1] throw_complex_domainerror(f::Symbol, x::Float64)
   @ Base.Math ./math.jl:33
[2] sqrt
   @ ./math.jl:627 [inlined]
[3] sqrt(x::Int64)
   @ Base.Math ./math.jl:1546
[4] top-level scope
   @
~/github/ProgrammingCourse-with-Julia-SimulationAnalysisAndLearningSystems/quarto/lecture-unit-1.qmd:200
```

```
z = sqrt(y + 0im)
```

```
0.0 + 1.4142135623730951im
```

Let's see some mathematical in-built functions:

```
exp(1)
```

```
2.718281828459045
```

```
#\euler + [TAB]
```

```
= 2.7182818284590...
```

```
log(2), log2(2^5), log10(10^3)
```

```
(2.0, 5.0, 3.0)
```

```
abs(-3.5), abs(3.5), abs(3 + 4im)
```

```
(3.5, 3.5, 5.0)
```

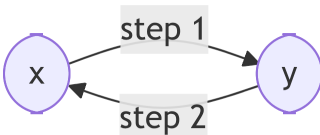
```
factorial(4)
```

```
24
```

2.1 Swapping values

In Julia, there is special notation ("syntactic sugar") for swapping values

If you do it in that naive way, then the following will happen.



```
x = 20
y = 5
```

```
#swapping x and y: attempt 1
x = y
```

```
y = x
```

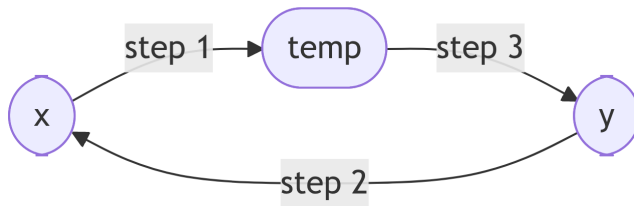
```
@show x; #This is the @show macro  
@show y;
```

```
x = 5
```

```
y = 5
```

So the value in `x` is overwritten and lost as soon as it is overwritten by the value in `y`.

This can be fixed by storing the value in `x` temporarily in another variable.



```
x = 20
```

```
y = 5
```

```
#swapping x and y: attempt 2
```

```
temp = x
```

```
x = y
```

```
y = temp
```

```
@show x;
```

```
@show y;
```

```
x = 5
```

```
y = 20
```

To simplify the notation for this, in Julia we can do it without using the variable `temp`:

```
x = 20
```

```
y = 5
```

```
x, y = y, x #Julia specific solution
```

```
@show x;
```

```
@show y;
```

```
x = 5
```

```
y = 20
```



2.2 Numeric Types

Variables have a type - think of it as the size and shape of the box. The command

```
typeof(x)
```

```
Int64
```

gives the type of the variable x (an integer value of size 8 bytes). The size can be obtained using the function `sizeof`, e.g.

```
sizeof(x)
```

8

The type `Int64` is the standard type for integers. Particular integer numbers are written without `.`:

```
typeof(32)
```

`Int64`

Another big class of numeric variables are floating point numbers. Specific floating point numbers are written with `.`, e.g.

```
y=34.23
typeof(y), sizeof(y)
```

(`Float64`, 8)

defines a Floating point number of size 8 bytes = 64 bits. Floating point numbers are also the result when we divide integer numbers, e.g.

```
r=3/4
println(r)
typeof(r)
```

0.75

`Float64`

and the result of many functions which typically return floating point numbers such as

```
result=cos(2)
result, typeof(result)
```

(-0.4161468365471424, `Float64`)

2.2.1 Type conversions

```
a=4;
x=Float64(a);
@show typeof(a) a;
@show typeof(x) x;
```

```
typeof(a) = Int64
a = 4
typeof(x) = Float64
x = 4.0
```

```
y=sqrt(5);
b=round(y);
@show typeof(y) y;
@show typeof(b) b;
```

```
typeof(y) = Float64
y = 2.23606797749979
typeof(b) = Float64
b = 2.0
```

2.3 Variables of type String (i.e. text) and Char(acter)

Variables can not only contain numbers, but pretty much every type of data, for example letters and text. The data type of single letters is called **Char**, which is short for character. The values of type **Char** are written with simple `'`, for example

```
c = 'a'
typeof(c)
```

Char

```
y = '\eta + [TAB]'
typeof(y), sizeof(y)
```

(Char, 4)

On the other hand, the data type for text is called String (`"a string of characters!"`). Keep in mind that double `"` are used to write Strings.

```
str = "Hello"
typeof(str)
```

String

The length of the string (number of characters) can be obtained from the built-in function `length`:

```
length(str)
```

5

But you can't do absolute value of a string:

```
abs("3.5")
```

```
MethodError: MethodError(abs, ("3.5",), 0x00000000000009a15)
```

```
MethodError: no method matching abs(::String)
```

The function `abs` exists, but no method is defined for this combination of argument types.

Closest candidates are:

```
abs(::Bool)
```

```
@ Base bool.jl:155
```

```
abs(::Pkg.Resolve.VersionWeight)
```

```
@ Pkg
```

```
~/julia/juliaup/julia-1.12.6+0.x64.linux.gnu/share/julia/stdlib/v1.12/Pkg/src/Resolve/versionweights.jl:32
```

```
abs(::Missing)
```

```
@ Base missing.jl:101
```

```
...
```

Stacktrace:

```
[1] top-level scope
```

```
@
```

```
~/github/ProgrammingCourse-with-Julia-SimulationAnalysisAndLearningSystems/quarto/lecture-unit-1.qmd:382
```

And for strings even some algebraic operations are defined,

```
s1 = "hello " #notice the extra space
s2 = "world"
@show typeof(s1);
s1*s2 #In Python it would have been x+y for concatenation
```

```
typeof(s1) = String
```

```
"hello world"
```

Even the exponential operator is defined for strings:

```
s = "hello "
y = 5
x^y
```

1024.0

These are examples of **operator (method) overloading** in Julia: For different data types, different versions of a function/method/operator can be defined.

```
s^(y-1)*s[1:end-1]
```

"hello hello hello hello hello"

Since the operator `^` has precedence of `*`, this is the same as

```
(s^(y-1))*s[1:end-1]
```

"hello hello hello hello hello"

2.4 Common errors: type mismatch

What if we did the brackets the other way?

```
s^((y-1)*s[1:end-1])
```

```
MethodError: MethodError(*, (4, "hello"), 0x00000000000009a17)
```

```
MethodError: no method matching *(::Int64, ::String)
```

The function ``*`` exists, but no method is defined for this combination of argument types.

Closest candidates are:

```
*(::Any, ::Any, ::Any, ::Any...)
  @ Base operators.jl:642
*(::Missing, ::Union{AbstractChar, AbstractString})
  @ Base missing.jl:174
*(::Real, ::Dates.Period)
  @ Dates
```

```
~/julia/juliaup/julia-1.12.6+0.x64.linux.gnu/share/julia/stdlib/v1.12/Dates/src/periods.jl:91
```

```
...
```

Stacktrace:

```
[1] top-level scope
```

```
@
```

```
~/github/ProgrammingCourse-with-Julia-SimulationAnalysisAndLearningSystems/quarto/lecture-unit-1.qmd:414
```

Here, Julia tries to identify an instance of the method `"*(..)"` which takes an Integer and a String as arguments (this is Julia's **"multiple dispatch"** paradigm), but doesn't succeed. The closest candidates are listed in the error message, but none of them fits (e.g., any argument of type Int64 can be converted into types Real, Number, Any, etc).

2.5 Indexing, Vectors and Matrices

Particular characters in a String can be retrieved using **indexing**. **Julia indexing is 1-based**, i.e. index 1 refers to the first letter, etc., whereas in other programming languages the first entry has index 0 be default.

The following diagram illustrates how to retrieve characters from a string by index:

String: "This is an example string!"

Index position (1-based):

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14	15	16	17	18	19	20	21	22	23	24	25	26
T	h	i	s		i	s		a	n		e	x	a	m	p	l	e		s	t	r	i	n	g	!

Examples:

```
str2[1]      → 'T'      (first character)
str2[7]      → 's'      (character at index 7)
str2[end]    → '!'      (last character)
str2[end-5:end] → "tring!" (substring from index 20 to 25)
str2[10:15]  → "nample"  (substring from index 10 to 15)
```

```
str2 = "This is an example string!"
```

```
"This is an example string!"
```

```
c1=str2[1]
println("The first letter in the string is: ", c1)
typeof(c1)
```

The first letter in the string is: T

Char

```
c7=str2[7]
println("and the 7th letter in the string is: ", c7)
```

and the 7th letter in the string is: s

The special index `end` can be used to the last character of the string

```
clast=str2[end]
println("and the final letter in the string is: ", clast)
```

and the final letter in the string is: !

Once can even retrieve sub-sections of a string, which gives another string, e.g.

```
string_end=str2[end-5:end]
println("and the final section of length 6 is: ", string_end)
```

and the final section of length 6 is: tring!

or

```
middle=str2[10:15]
println("and a middle section of length 6 is: ", middle)
```

and a middle section of length 6 is: n exam

Another example of types of variables that admit indexing are vectors

```
u=[1,2,3]
u[2]=5
v=u
```

3-element Vector{Int64}:

```
1
5
3
```

and matrices

```
M=[1 2 3; 4 5 6; 7 8 9]
M*v
```

3-element Vector{Int64}:

```
20
```

47
74

Note that dealing with such higher-dimensional objects is one of the big strengths of Julia and will be discussed in the coming units. For now, vectors (and matrices) only serve as examples of composite variables.

2.6 Mutable vs immutable composite types

A big difference between Strings on the one hand and collections such as Vectors as well as Matrices on the other hand is that Strings in Julia are immutable whereas Vectors and Matrices are mutable. This means that Strings can not be modified in hindsight, whereas Vectors (and Matrices) can be modified after creation.

```
str="Here, I am creating a string variable"  
str[5]='c'
```

```
MethodError: MethodError(setindex!, ("Here, I am creating a string variable", 'c', 5),  
0x00000000000009a20)  
MethodError: no method matching setindex!{::String, ::Char, ::Int64}  
The function `setindex!` exists, but no method is defined for this combination of argument types.  
Stacktrace:  
 [1] top-level scope  
      @  
~/github/ProgrammingCourse-with-Julia-SimulationAnalysisAndLearningSystems/quarto/lecture-unit-1.qmd:498
```

This creates an error whereas for a Matrix

```
v=[1,2,3]  
v[1]=10  
@show(v)  
M=[1.0 2.0 3; 4 5 6; 7 8 9]  
M[1, 2]=200.0  
@show(M)
```

```
v = [10, 2, 3]  
M = [1.0 200.0 3.0; 4.0 5.0 6.0; 7.0 8.0 9.0]  
  
3×3 Matrix{Float64}:  
 1.0  200.0  3.0  
 4.0   5.0  6.0  
 7.0   8.0  9.0
```

2.7 Storage-by-reference vs storage-by-value

Variables of type String are more complex than those for simple numbers. They are composed of a sequence of simpler components of type **Char**. In particular, the length of a String can vary, and therefore also the amount of memory it occupies.

For these reasons, Strings are examples of **composite types**, while the simple datatypes such as those for basic integers and floating point numbers, and the one of characters are called **primitive types**. This can be verified using the built-in function **isbits** which returns **true** (another type of variable - see below) for primitive types, and false for composite types.

```
isbits(x), isbits(c), isbits(str)
```

```
(true, true, false)
```

This has important consequence for how variables are stored in memory. Variables of **primitive types**, i.e. for which the variable **directly** refers to the value of the variable, are stored IN the variable - in the box denoted by the name of the variable (see figure above).

Variables of **composite types**, on the other hand, such as Strings do not refer directly to their content, but to the address (**reference**, pointer) in memory where the content is stored. Think of the reference as the shelf number in the computer memory which plays the role of a storage facility. For example in the figure above, the String variable `str` contains the reference (address) `5` which is the position in memory where the actual string containing “Heelo” is stored

This has striking consequences. For example when assigning the content of one primitive variable to another variable, only the content is copied

```
x=10
y=x
```

10

so we can change the content of one variable without modifying the content of the other one.

```
x=100
println(y)
```

10

On the other hand, for a composite type such as vectors and matrices,

```
u=[1,2,3]
v=u
```

3-element Vector{Int64}:

1
2
3

This defines a vector of length 3 and copies the reference to this vector from `u` into `v`.

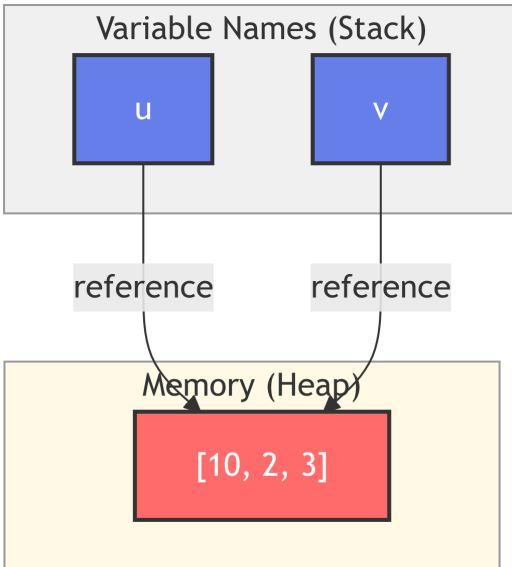
When we modify the content of `u` using indexing, we also modify the content of `v`:

```
u[1]=10
@show(v)
```

`v = [10, 2, 3]`

3-element Vector{Int64}:

10
2
3



The reason is that using indexing, we directly modify the section in memory, to which both references in `u` and in `v` are pointing.

3 Logical statements and conditional execution

```
true, false #In Python it is True and False (caps first letter)
```

```
(true, false)
```

```
typeof(true)
```

```
Bool
```

```
@show Int(true);
@show Int(false);
```

```
Int(true) = 1
Int(false) = 0
```

3.1 Logical operators

```
5 == 2 + 3 # check for equality
```

```
true
```

```
5 != 2 + 3 # check for not being equal (!=)
```

```
false
```

```
false && false, false && true, true && false, true && true #logical AND
```

```
(false, false, false, true)
```

```
false || false, false || true, true || false, true || true #logical OR
```

```
(false, true, true, true)
```

```
(2 != 3) || (2 == 3)
```

```
true
```

```
!(2 == 3) # ! (not)
```

```
true
```

For the next block, you need to have the package `Random` installed: To install it, change to package mode using `]`, and use `add Random`.

The REPL modes are `*` ; to access the shell/terminal temporarily , `* ?` for help mode `* ]` for package mode `*` Ctrl-C or Backspace brings you back to the standard “Julian” prompt.

```
using Random
```

```
Random.seed!(7) #The exclamation mark denotes functions which change the environment  
(side-effects).
```

```
x = rand(1:100) #random number within 1, 2, ..., 100  
y = rand(1:100) #random number within 1, 2, ..., 100
```

```
@show x, y;
```

```
(x == y) || (x != y)
```

```
(x, y) = (25, 72)
```

```
true
```

The command `Random.seed!` sets the seed value for the random number generator. Without it, an almost random seed value is generated and random numbers will differ every time you evaluate the following ‘rand’ commands. If you set the seed value, then random numbers will always be the same - every time you run the script (which can be useful for debugging, or comparison).

```
x < y, x<=y, x == y, x > y, x != y # \le or \ge + [TAB]
```

```
(true, true, true, false, false)
```

```
(x == y) && (x != y)
```

```
false
```

3.2 Logical operators for composite types

```
x=[1,2,3]  
y=[1,2,3]  
x==y
```

```
true
```

compares the content of `x` to the content of `y`. To check whether `x` and `y` are physically identical (same reference) use

```
@show x===y;  
z=y  
@show z===y;
```

```
x === y = false
```

```
z === y = true
```

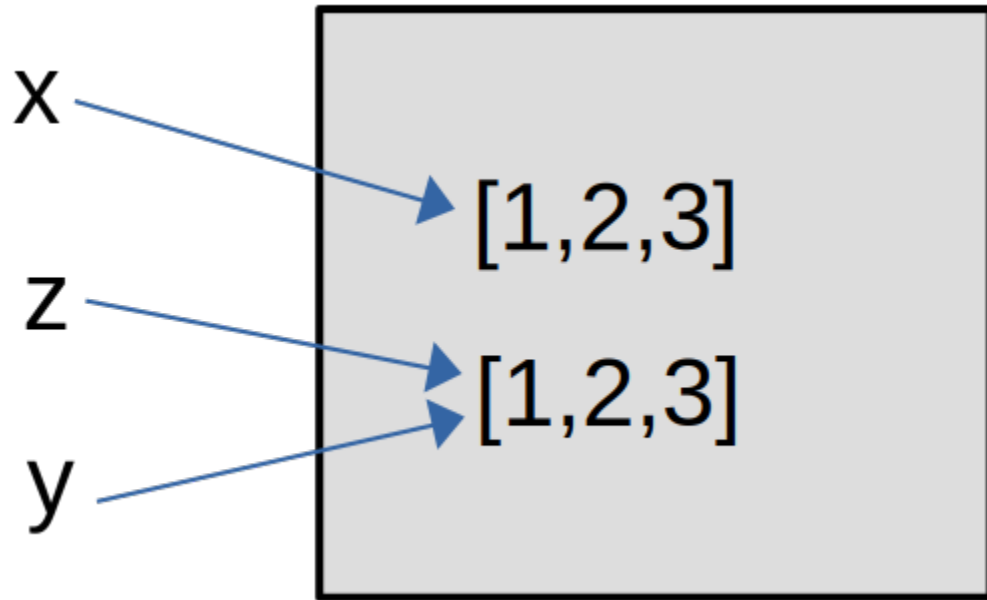
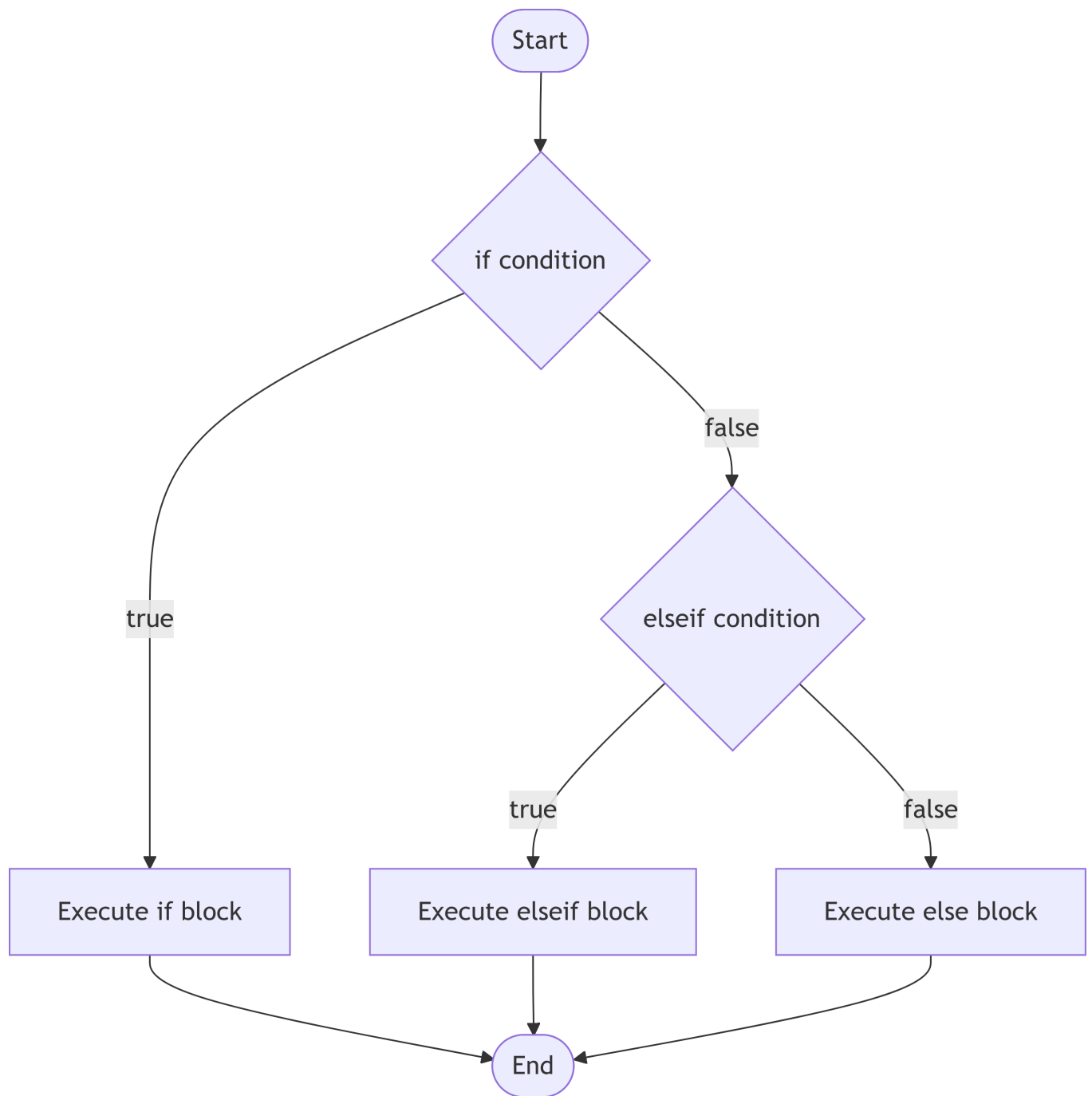


Figure 2: composite types

3.3 Conditional execution (if-elseif-else)



```
if 2 < 3 && 2 > 3
  println("The world has gone crazy")
end
```

```
if 2 < 3 || 2 > 3
  println("The world makes sense")
end
```

The world makes sense

```
x = 25.3
if x < 30
    println("It is less than 30")
else
    println("It is greater or equal to 30")
end
```

It is less than 30

```
x = 25.3
if x < 20
    println("It is less than 20")
elseif x < 30
    println("It is less than 30 but not less than 20")
else
    println("It is greater or equal to 30")
end
```

It is less than 30 but not less than 20

Let's use it to compute an absolute value.

```
x = -3 # some input
if x < 0
    println(-x)
else
    println(x)
end
```

3

3.3.1 Compact ways of formulating if clauses

Use either the **ternary operator** `condition ? dothisiftrue : dothisiffalse`

```
x = -3 # some input
absx = x < 0 ? -x : x
```

3

or using logical AND (`&&`), making use of Julia's **lazy evaluation of logical operators**,

```
x = -3 # some input
x < 0 && println("This is a negative number!")
```

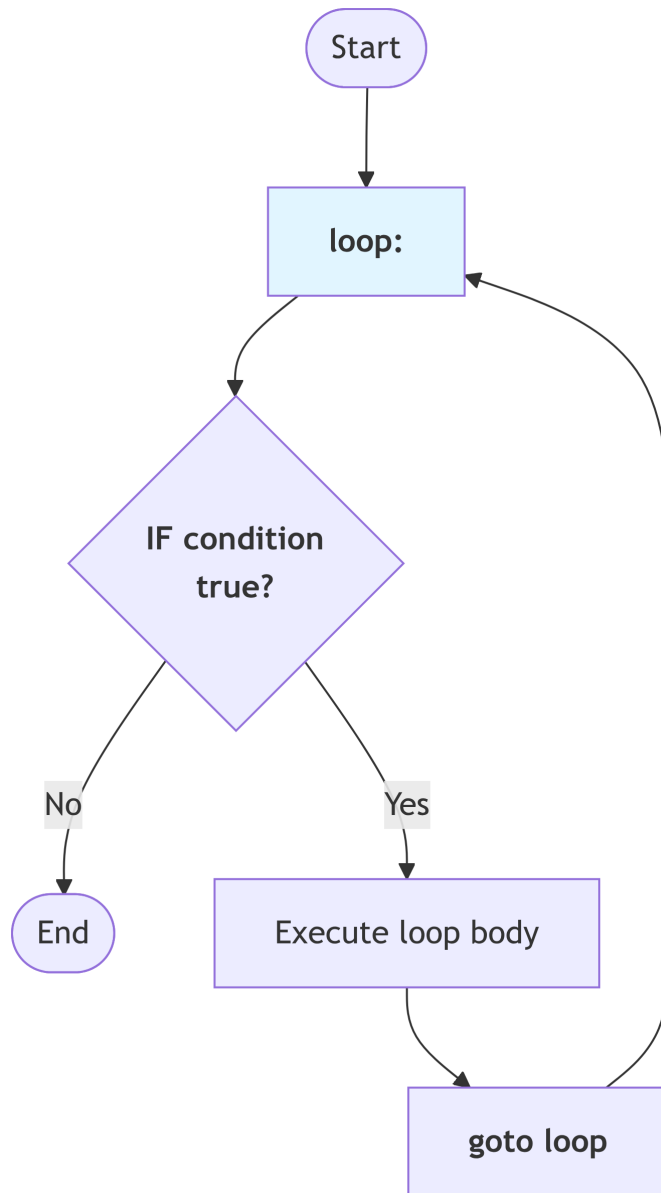
This is a negative number!

Here, the second condition for the AND clause `&&` is only evaluated if the first condition evaluates to true. Effectively this behaves like a single-line if statement.

4 Loops

You might want to execute a specific section of your code more than once, for example for a certain number of times, or until a condition is reached. The section of a program which is structured in this way is called a **loop**.

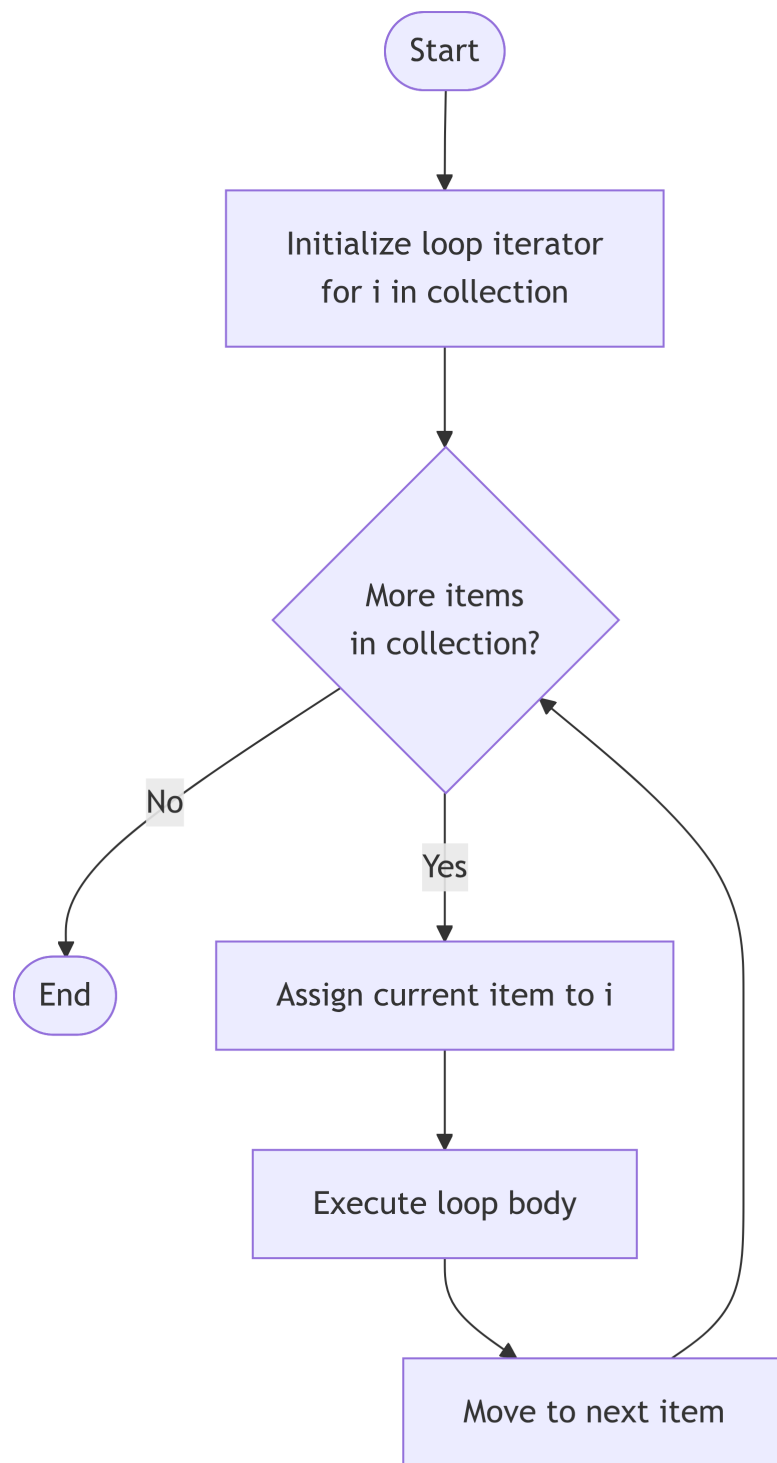
In principle, a loop can be implemented by combining an if-statement which checks whether the loop should be executed one more time or not, and a goto statement by which program execution jumps back to the beginning of the loop section.



In many programming languages, particularly older ones, such `goto` statements exist, but they make code error-prone as well as hard to read and to maintain. For that reason more modern programming languages either don't include any type of `goto` command, or just in the form of macros which is the case for Julia.

It is pretty much always better to implement loops through dedicated control structures, namely `for` loops and `while` loops.

4.1 For loops



```
for i in 1:5
    println(i)
end
```

```
2
3
4
5
```

```
for i in 1:3
    println(i)
end
```

```
1
2
3
```

```
for i 1:3 # \in + [TAB]
    println(i)
end
```

```
1
2
3
```

```
for _ 1:3 # \in + [TAB]
    println("hello")
end
```

```
hello
hello
hello
```

```
total = 0
max_val = 10
for i 1:max_val
    global total # This line can be ignored by now
    total = total + i
end
println("The total is: $total")
println("And using a formula: ", max_val*(max_val+1)/2)
```

The total is: 55

And using a formula: 55.0

Notice the above 55 vs. 55.0. This is because of division which converts an integer to a float.

Using the command **break**, loops can be left at any time.

```
for i 1:13 # \in + [TAB]
    if i<5
        println("hello $i")
    else
        break
    end
end
```

```
hello 1
hello 2
hello 3
hello 4
```

Using the command **continue**, code execution continues at the start of the loop

```

for i 1:13 # \in + [TAB]
  if i<10
    continue
  else
    println("hello $i")
  end
end
end

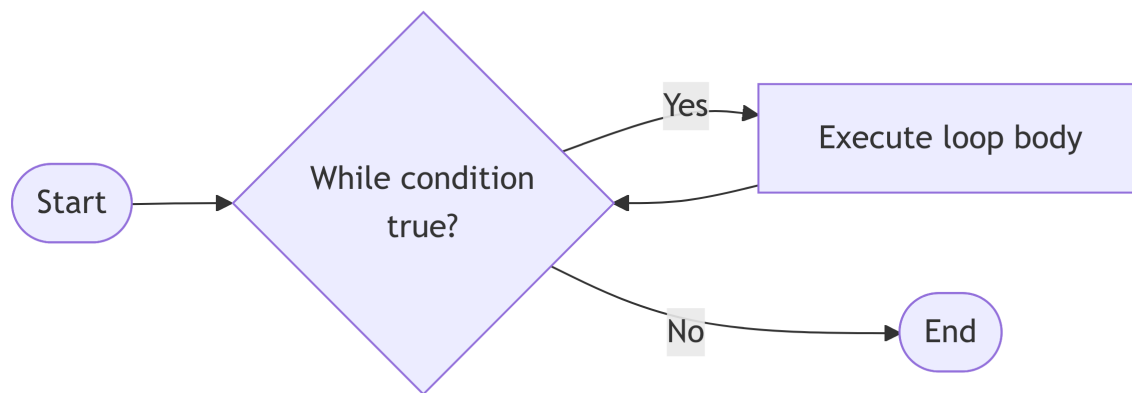
```

```

hello 10
hello 11
hello 12
hello 13

```

4.2 While loops



While loops give you more control over the loop.

```

i = 1
while i 3 # do the following as long as i is smaller or equal than 3
  global i
  println(i)
  i = i + 1
end

```

```

1
2
3

```

The hailstone sequence: If a number is even, half it, if it is odd, multiply by 3 and add 1. Stop when you reach 1.

```

n = 7
while n != 1
  global n
  print(n, ", ")
  if n % 2 == 0 # modulo
    n = n ÷ 2 # \div + [TAB] Integer division
  else
    n = 3n + 1
  end
end
println(n)

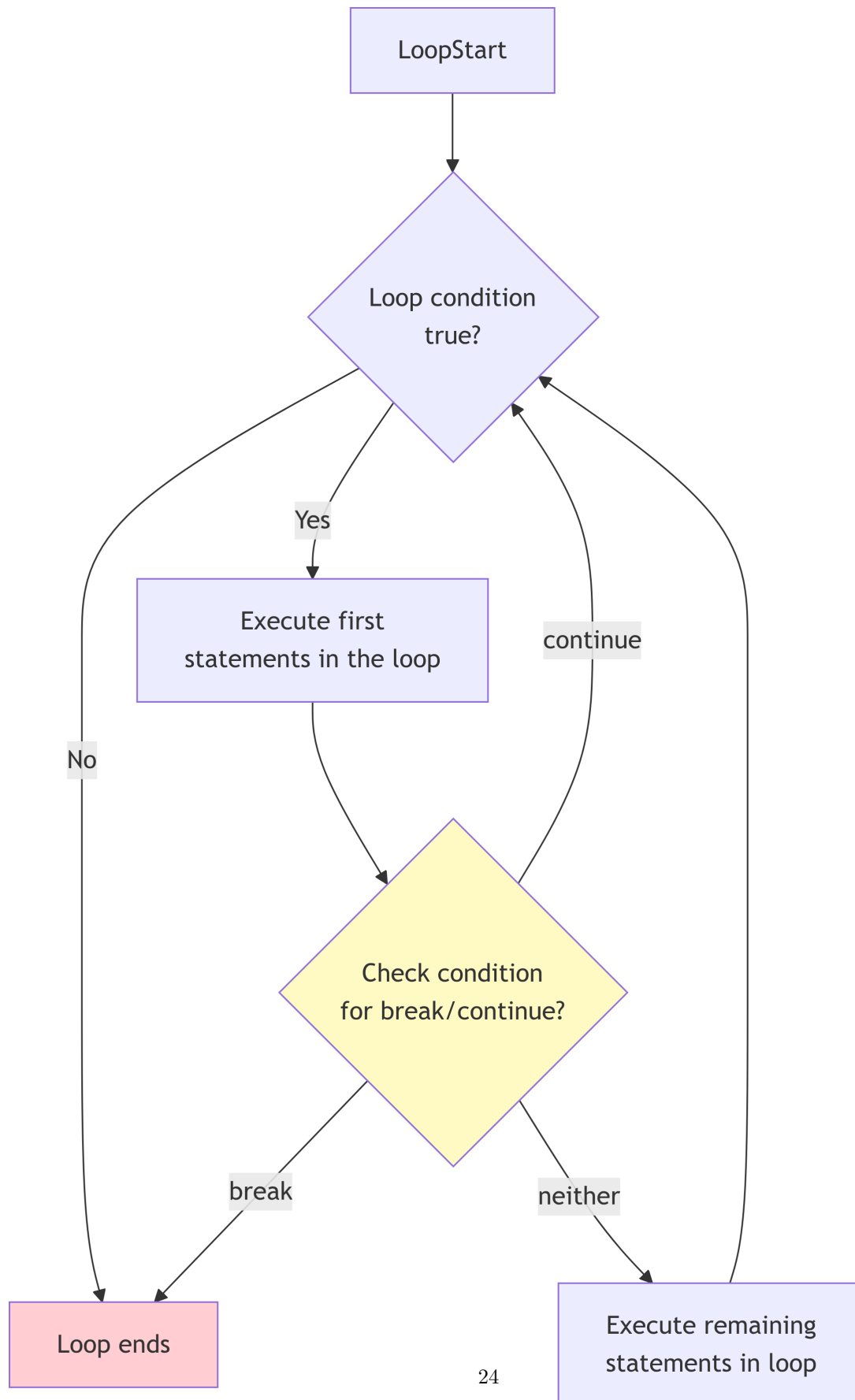
```

```

7, 22, 11, 34, 17, 52, 26, 13, 40, 20, 10, 5, 16, 8, 4, 2, 1

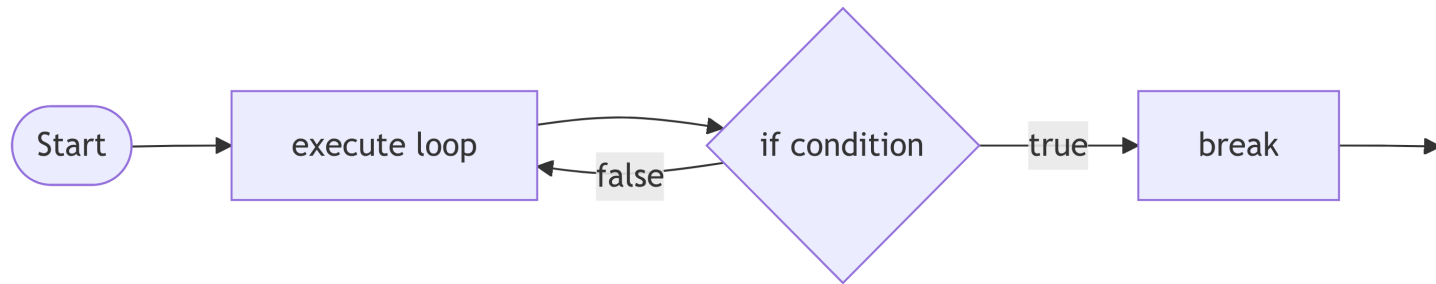
```


4.3 break and continue



Using the command `break`, loops can be left at any time.

4.4 Howto implement do-while loops in Julia

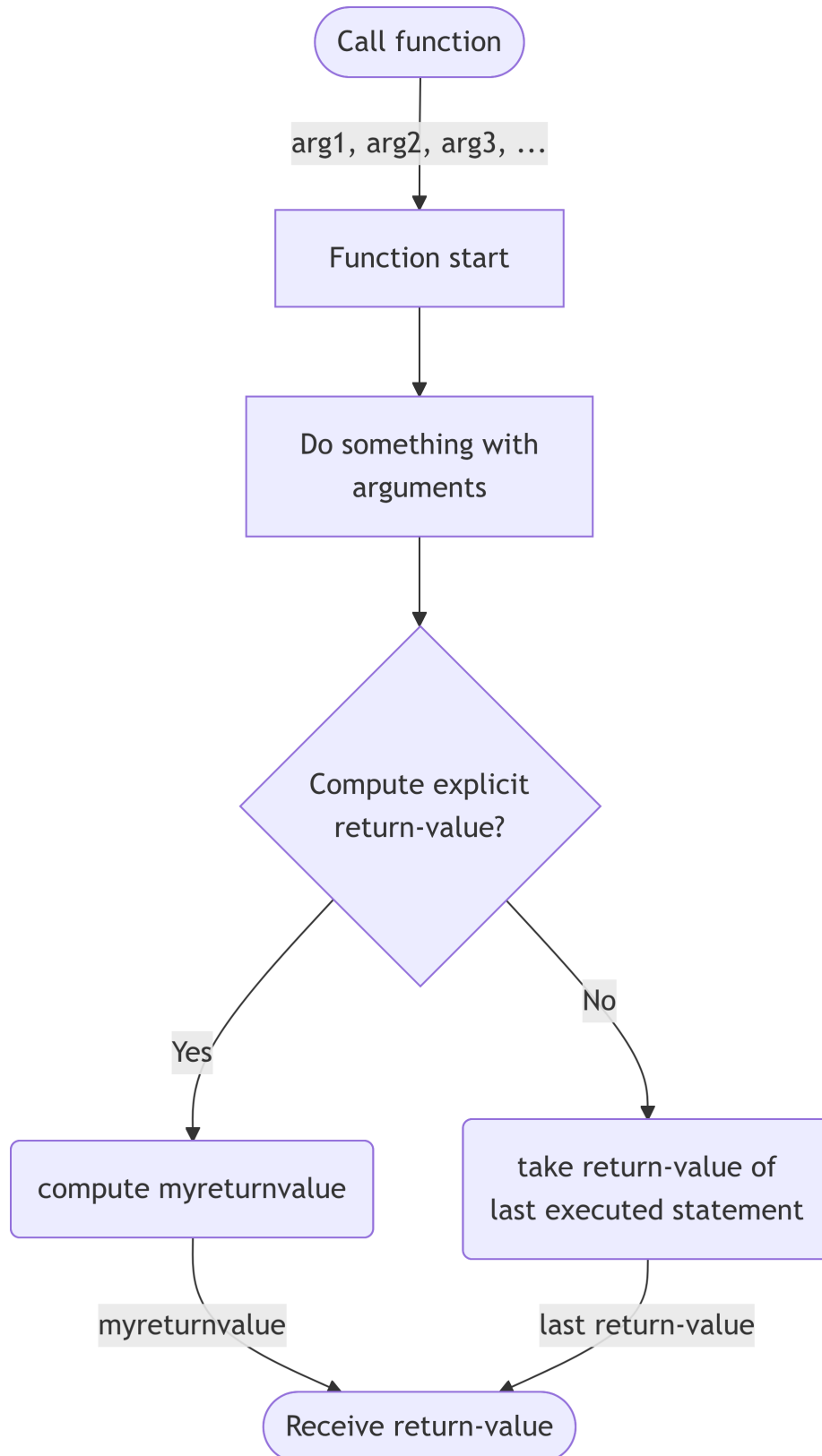


In do-while loops the loop is executed as least once before the termination condition is evaluated!

```
i=0
while true
    # do stuff
    println(i)
    i = i + 1
    if i>5
        break
    end
    # shorter: i>5 || break
end
```

```
0
1
2
3
4
5
```

5 Creating your own functions



We already had logic for an absolute value function (of real values). Now let's make a function out of it:

```
function my_abs(x)
  if x < 0
    return -x
  else
    return x
  end
end
```

my_abs (generic function with 1 method)

We can also implement this as,

```
function my_abs(x)
  if x < 0
    return -x
  end
  return x
end
```

my_abs (generic function with 1 method)

Or even,

```
function my_abs(x)
  if x < 0
    return -x
  end
  x
end
```

my_abs (generic function with 1 method)

which uses that functions by default return the output of the last command.

```
@show my_abs(-3.5);
@show my_abs(2.3);
@show my_abs(0);
```

```
my_abs(-3.5) = 3.5
my_abs(2.3) = 2.3
my_abs(0) = 0
```

Functions don't have to have an argument or a return value:

```
function print_my_details()
  println("Name: Jacob")
  println("Occupation: diesel mechanic")
  return nothing
end

print_my_details()
```

Name: Jacob

Occupation: diesel mechanic

Let's see the hailstone sequence for the first 10 integers:

```
#let's "wrap" the code we had before in a function
function hailstone(n_start)
  n = n_start
  while n != 1
```

```

print(n, ", ")
if n % 2 == 0
  n = n ÷ 2
else
  n = 3n + 1
end
end
println(n)
return nothing
end

hailstone(7)

```

7, 22, 11, 34, 17, 52, 26, 13, 40, 20, 10, 5, 16, 8, 4, 2, 1

```

println("Hailstone sequences: ")
for n in 1:10
  hailstone(n)
end

```

Hailstone sequences:

```

1
2, 1
3, 10, 5, 16, 8, 4, 2, 1
4, 2, 1
5, 16, 8, 4, 2, 1
6, 3, 10, 5, 16, 8, 4, 2, 1
7, 22, 11, 34, 17, 52, 26, 13, 40, 20, 10, 5, 16, 8, 4, 2, 1
8, 4, 2, 1
9, 28, 14, 7, 22, 11, 34, 17, 52, 26, 13, 40, 20, 10, 5, 16, 8, 4, 2, 1
10, 5, 16, 8, 4, 2, 1

```

5.1 Alternative, more compact ways, of defining functions

When you can implement a function in one line, you can avoid using the `function` keyword and instead use **mathematical notation for defining functions**

```

times_2(x) = 2x

@show times_2(times_2(10)) #this uses the function twice.
@show (times_2 times_2)(10) # alternative way of writing function composition
@show [1,2,3] |> times_2; # or, using piping operator |>

```

```

times_2(times_2(10)) = 40
(times_2 times_2)(10) = 40
[1, 2, 3] |> times_2 = [2, 4, 6]

```

One can even define **anonymous function** without function names

```

[1,2,3] |> (x->2x)

```

```

3-element Vector{Int64}:
 2
 4
 6

```

5.2 Functions for arrays (Vectors, Matrices ...)

Let's make a function that sums up entries of an array (assuming it is an array of numbers).

```
function my_sum(input_array)
  total = 0
  for i in 1:length(input_array)
    total += input_array[i]
  end
  return total
end

a = [1, 10, 100, 1000]
my_sum(a)
```

1111

There is also an in-built function for this.

```
sum(a)
```

1111

Arrays can be extended with the `push!` function. Note that the `!` is part of the function name and indicates to us that the function modifies the array.

```
my_array = Int[] #empty array of integers
push!(my_array, -3)
@show my_array
push!(my_array, 10)
@show my_array;
```

```
my_array = [-3]
my_array = [-3, 10]
```

Let's modify our `hailstone` function to return an array with the sequence instead of printing the sequence.

```
function hailstone(n_start)
  sequence = Int[]
  n = n_start
  while n != 1
    push!(sequence, n) # was before print(n, ", ")
    if n % 2 == 0
      n = n ÷ 2
    else
      n = 3n + 1
    end
  end
  push!(sequence, n) # was before println(n)
  return sequence # was before return nothing
end

hailstone(7)
```

17-element Vector{Int64}:

```
 7
22
11
34
17
52
```

26
13
40
20
10
5
16
8
4
2
1

The [Collatz Conjecture](#) says that for every starting value the sequence eventually hits 1. Let's try to disprove it by seeing if this program gets stuck.

```
for n in 1:10^3
    hailstone(n)
end
```

It didn't get stuck (try even changing 10^3 to 10^6).

Now let's see what was the longest sequence.

```
length_of_longest = 0
n_of_longest = 1
for n in 1:10^3
    global length_of_longest, n_of_longest
    seq_len = length(hailstone(n))
    if seq_len > length_of_longest
        length_of_longest = seq_len
        n_of_longest = n
    end
end

println("Longest sequence is of length $length_of_longest when you start at $n_of_longest.")
```

Longest sequence is of length 179 when you start at 871.

One very easy way to create an array is via an array comprehension.

```
[i^2 for i in 1:10]
```

10-element Vector{Int64}:

1
4
9
16
25
36
49
64
81
100

The `maximum` function finds the maximal value of an array. We can find the 179 value from above just like this.

```
maximum([length(hailstone(n)) for n in 1:10^3])
```

179

What if we wanted to also know which index attains this maximum? See the `findmax` function.

```
findmax([length(hailstone(n)) for n in 1:103])
```

(179, 871)

5.3 Classroom Micro-Projects

Here are several micro-projects aimed at providing practice using the concepts above. For each of them you may need a bit more functionality and in-built functions that what we explored so far. You can get that from web-search, LLM-help, peer help, or staff help.

Micro-Project 1: Write a little program in that gives a student a mathematics arithmetic quiz with the operations `+`, `-` and `*`. It has input numbers in the range from 1 to 200. Students get asked questions and need to respond with the correct answer. After 10 questions the students gets a summary of how many they got correct and what they got wrong. You may need to explore the `readline` and `parse` functions.

Micro-Project 2: Write a little program that is a Tik-Tak-Toe game between two players. On each turn, the state of the board is re-printed. You can use 1,...,9 as input for the cells.

Micro-Project 3: Write a program that works on some fixed long string (e.g. several paragraphs of text such as the text here describing the micro projects). The program should output the character count, the word count, and perhaps other statistics about the text.

5.4 Practice questions

1. Consider the Julia code:

```
a = ["$i" for i in 1:3]
s = a[1]*a[2]*a[3]
```

What is the type and value of `s`?

2. You want to write a function `my_minimum` that gets an array of numbers and returns the minimal value in the array. Do not use the `minimum` in-built function as part of your answer.

```
function my_minimum(a)

    return minimal_value
end
```

Fill in the code for the function.

3. You want to write a Julia function `num_sub_str` which accepts a string `main_string` and a string `sub_string`, and returns a count of how many times `sub_string` is in `main_string`.

```
function num_sub_str(main_string, sub_string)

    return number_occurrences
end
```

Fill in the code for the function.

4. Consider the Julia function, `tamid_nahon` which gets two boolean values as inputs, `a`, and `b`.

```
function tamid_nahon(a, b)
    return !(a && b) == !a || !b
end
```

For what combinations of `a` and `b` is the return value `true`? For what is it `false`?

5. The Fibonacci sequence is 0, 1, 1, 2, 3, 5, 8, 13, 21, 34, ... (every element is the sum of the previous two and the initialization is 0, 1). Write a Julia function that computes the first `n` terms of the Fibonacci sequence, returning these terms in an array.

```
function fibonacci(n)
    arr = [0, 1]

    return arr
end
```

Fill in the code for the function.